

■ Labor Precautions

Women's Specialists of Clear Lake
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Signs to watch for as your due date approaches

As you approach the end of your pregnancy, your body will begin sending signals that labor may be near. Understanding what to watch for — and knowing when to call or head to Labor & Delivery — will help you feel prepared and confident. Remember: when in doubt, always call us. We would rather hear from you.

■ GO TO LABOR & DELIVERY IMMEDIATELY if you experience any of these:

- Heavy vaginal bleeding (more than a normal period)
- Your water breaks (sudden gush or steady trickle of fluid)
- Baby has stopped moving or is moving significantly less
- Severe abdominal pain or pressure
- Contractions before 37 weeks (preterm labor)
- Sudden severe headache, vision changes, or facial swelling

EARLY SIGNS LABOR IS NEAR

These signs may appear days or even weeks before active labor begins. They don't necessarily mean you need to go in right away — just that things are progressing.

- **Lightening ("baby dropping")** — Your baby moves lower into the pelvis. You may feel less pressure under your ribs and breathe easier, but notice more pelvic heaviness.
- **Increased pelvic pressure** — A feeling of heaviness or pressure in the lower pelvis or rectum.
- **Bloody show** — Pink, brown, or blood-tinged mucus discharge. This is the mucus plug passing — normal and expected.
- **Changes in bowel habits** — Loose stools or increased frequency can occur as hormones shift.
- **Braxton Hicks contractions becoming stronger** — More frequent or uncomfortable tightening, but still irregular.
- **Nesting urge** — A sudden burst of energy and desire to clean or organize. Completely normal.

SIGNS YOU MAY BE IN LABOR

True labor contractions follow a pattern. Use the **5-1-1 rule** to know when to call or go in:

5	1	1
minutes apart	minute long	hour consistently

Contractions that are **5 minutes apart, lasting 1 minute each, for 1 hour** — call us or head to Labor & Delivery.

Other signs to call about:

- Water breaking — any gush or trickle of clear fluid
- Contractions that do not ease with rest, water, or changing positions
- Decreased fetal movement (see Kick Counts pamphlet)
- Any bleeding heavier than spotting

■ *Trust your instincts. You know your body best. If something feels off, call us — we are always here to help.*

WHEN TO CALL (281) 557-0300

Call during office hours:

- Contractions every 5 min for 1 hour (5-1-1 rule)
- Decreased fetal movement
- Bloody show or unusual discharge
- Any concern or question

Call after hours / go to L&D:

- Heavy bleeding or water breaking
- Baby not moving
- Severe pain or preterm contractions
- Severe headache or vision changes

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